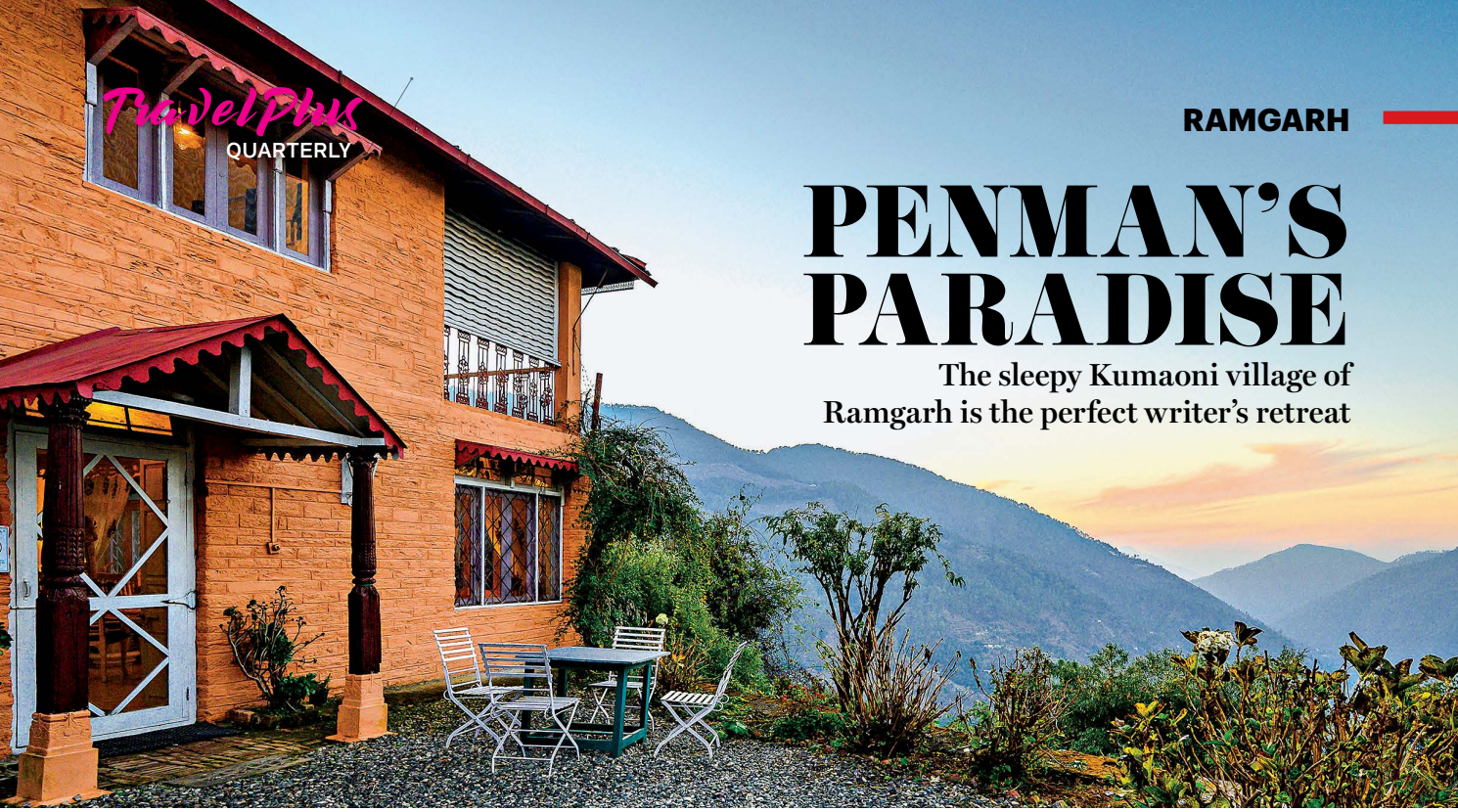
PENMAN'S PARADISE

The sleepy Kumaoni village of Ramgarh is the perfect writer's retreat



By Arjun Singh Kadian



QUIET ELEGANCE The Rose Cottage and (top) the Cliff House facade at The Ramgarh Bungalows

Shadowed by blue skies and enveloped by lush greenery, the Kumaoni village of Ramgarh is a votary of the idyllic life. I visited Ramgarh, about 30 kilometres from Bhimtal, for a well-deserved break after some dreary research work for my next book.

Away from the competing traffic headed to Nainital, the village brings the slow-life into action. The quiet is absolute, away from the ambient noise that wraps our urban areas. The mind begins to rest, the shoulders relax, the eyes open wide and a blissful smile takes over.

All roads of the village led to my stay—The Ramgarh Bungalows by Neemrana 'Non-Hotel' Hotels, 19th-century inspection bungalows overlooking this 'Fruit Bowl of Kumaon'. In fact, Neemrana has brought within its walls all the flavours of the region. The staff includes well-trained locals, the kitchen offers Kumaoni food among other cuisines, the flowers and trees bring nature inside and the restored colonial balconies make it meditative. To top it all, there's also a jam factory on the premises employing locals.

The Himalayas put you into a contemplative mode. My routine in Ramgarh comprised waking up early, doing some reading, walking through the bridle paths or trekking up the hills, sleeping with better dreams and waking up renewed. This sleepy corner of Kumaon converted the Himachal lover in me. And I am not the only one!

Ramgarh is steeped in history and literature. Rabindranath Tagore composed several of his poems and even parts of his magnum opus *Gitanjali* here. He first visited Ramgarh and Almora in the early 20th century, when doctors suggested that the Himalayan air could do his daughter Renuka, suffering from tuberculosis, some good.

In fact, Neemrana's Writers' Bungalow is a fine repository of Ramgarh's literary tradition. It was here, surrounded by tranquillity, that Aman Nath penned his *Jaipur: The Last Destination* (1993). Ramdhari Singh 'Dinkar' and Sachchidananda Hirananda Vatsyayan have also enriched Ramgarh's history. Poet Mahadevi Verma was also charmed by the village.

I'd argue three days in Ramgarh aren't enough. No wonder those who set out for the Himalayas are tempted to never come back!

The Ramgarh Bungalows comprise five English cottages. Contact: 0124-4666166, reservations@neemranahotels.com, www.neemranahotels.com